



Request for Participation: Accessible Transportation Resource Center Community of Practice

Launched in 2022, the Accessible Transportation Resource Center (ATRC) is a national technical assistance center, funded by the Administration for Community Living (ACL). ATRC promotes greater awareness, adoption and use of assistive technology and other accessibility strategies that make transportation systems, services, vehicles, program enrollment locations and websites, and apps accessible and responsive to the needs of people with disabilities, older adults and family caregivers and others in their support network. ATRC's goals are to:

- identify and disseminate accessibility strategies
- increase awareness and adoption of assistive technology and mobility-on-demand transportation systems
- ultimately, create greater access to transportation for people with disabilities and older adults.

In support of its goals, the ATRC is issuing this application for underserved communities to apply to participate in the **ATRC Transportation Accessibility Community of Practice (CoP)**. ATRC seeks to work with 5 historically underserved communities (two of which will be rural) to address their identified transportation accessibility problem through the Transportation Accessibility Community of Practice.

People with disabilities and older adults use transportation to engage in many aspects of daily life, including accessing healthy food, getting to school, attending doctor appointments, seeing friends and family, and going to work. Yet with an estimated 25.5 million Americans reportedly experiencing travel-limiting disabilities, many individuals with disabilities and older adults confront a variety of barriers in accessing transportation.¹ These barriers are persistent and exacerbated for individuals living in rural areas, especially in under-resourced rural areas, and those living in poverty. The availability of accessible transportation options that are convenient, affordable, and safe remains a top concern of people with disabilities, older adults, family caregivers and others in their support network and the communities where they live.

Definitions of Key Terms for This Application

Accessible Transportation: Accessible transportation is defined as transportation that everyone can access and use. Transportation options often do not include features that accommodate the needs of older adults and

¹ University of Pittsburgh (2022). Transportation for People with Disabilities, UTC Spotlight, January 2022 - https://www.transportation.gov/sites/dot.gov/files/2022-01/UTC%20Newsletter_Q1_Jan2022.pdf

people with disabilities, making transportation inaccessible to these populations. Accessibility barriers (e.g., the lack of a lift-equipped vehicle, poorly maintained sidewalks, or difficult-to-read signage) can prevent communities and individuals from using some transportation services.

ATRC Project Team: Staff of the ATRC led by the Community Transportation Association of America (CTAA), partnered with US Aging, the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston, and DJB Evaluation.

Community of Practice (CoP): A group of people who share a common concern, a set of problems, or an interest in a topic and who come together to fulfill both individual and group goals. The overall objective of the ATRC CoP is to increase, improve and/or expand the availability and use of accessible transportation in 5 historically underserved communities. CoP members will interact and communicate regularly, share tools, resources and best practices, and engage in joint activities to achieve their goals.

Participants: People with disabilities, older adults, and their caregivers who have lived experience in accessible transportation and are not serving as an organizational representative involved in the project. These individuals are distinct from *Partnering Organizations*, defined below.

Partnering Organizations: Organizations that will work with CoP *Participants* to achieve the goals of the CoP. Examples include, but are not limited to: Area Agencies on Aging, area planning agencies, transportation organizations, Centers for Independent Living, Aging and Disability Resource Centers, publicly assisted housing providers/operators, State or Territory Assistive Technology Act programs, health care providers, businesses, VA Medical Centers, tribal organizations, advocacy groups, community organizations, local elected officials, and local government organizations.

Underserved: Populations or communities sharing a particular characteristic, that have been systematically denied a full opportunity to participate in aspects of economic, social, and civic life.

Description of ATRC Community of Practice

The ATRC CoP will consist of five community teams who apply for and are selected by the ATRC to participate for an initial 12-month period, to increase, improve and expand the availability and use of accessible transportation in their underserved communities.

Community Teams

1. **Represent underserved community:** The community team will represent an underserved community as defined by ACL and ATRC under *Key Terms* (above), and be from a specific geographic region (city, town, county, tribal territory, or state).
2. **Mutual learning and problem solving:** Each of the 5 community teams selected will engage in mutual learning and problem solving among the community team members to meet needs specific to their communities and population and use their understanding and expertise regarding their community needs to address transportation access and utilization.
3. **Problem identification:** In the application process, each community team will identify an accessible transportation problem they plan to address.
4. **Team members:** Each team will include *Participants* (as defined above), and one or more *Partner Organizations* from their specific geographic region that are familiar with the problem and willing to work together to implement a solution in the identified community.
5. **Driven by participants:** The organization and operation of each community team will be driven by the Participants on the team, reflective of the local culture, with the expectation that older adults, people with disabilities, and caregivers, will be actively and meaningfully involved, and take on leadership roles to address the identified transportation accessibility problem and achieve the goal defined in their

application. The Pathway to Inclusion ([available at this link](#)) will be used as a model for meaningful participation and inclusion.

6. **Meeting frequency:** Community teams will be expected to meet on a monthly basis (either in-person or virtually), starting in September 2024, and may meet more often as needed. Community teams will be expected to meet for a minimum of 12 months through August 2025.
7. **ATRC team support:** Each community team will be assigned a liaison from the ATRC project team. As the CoP commences, ATRC staff will work inclusively with community team members to develop a structure that results in active and meaningful participation by all members to address priority issues. The ATRC project team liaison will also provide ongoing technical assistance and support to the community team to facilitate their progress in finalizing and implementing their solution.
8. **Charter:** Upon formation, each community team will develop its own charter, based on a template provided by ATRC, that addresses:
 - a. Description of the geographical transportation accessibility problem that will be addressed.
 - b. Goals of the community team as it relates to improving transportation accessibility in the geographical area.
 - c. Responsibilities of each Participant and Partner Organization.
 - d. Method for decision-making with an emphasis on an inclusive and accessible process for participation, respect for a diversity of viewpoints, and coming to consensus.
9. **Work plan:** In addition, with the support of ATRC staff, at its initiation, each community team will develop a work plan with timelines to refine and implement their solution that will serve as the basis for the work and activities of the community team.
10. **Quarterly reports:** Community teams will report quarterly on use of funds, along with a short narrative on activities, and progress toward relevant goals identified by the group.

National CoP

1. Together the 5 community teams will make up the ATRC national CoP.
2. Representatives from each of the 5 community teams will meet virtually as a group every other month with ATRC staff as part of the national CoP, to share and discuss collective issues, learnings, and engage in group-problem solving.
3. Via the national CoP, there will be opportunities to work with other communities and populations of need to address common transportation barriers and implement solutions.

Funding

- Each local CoP will receive a sub-grant of up to \$15,000² per year, to support the following activities: stipends for Participants as needed, accommodations, ASL interpretation, language translation, and development of materials (available in multiple languages as needed).
- Continuation of CoP funded activities will be based on outcomes of each Community Team from the previously funded year, and ongoing availability of federal funds.

² *contingent upon availability of funds, additional funding for awards may be provided to the communities selected.*

Selection Criteria

- A) **Underserved community:** The community team must represent an underserved community as defined by ACL and ATRC. An underserved community is defined as populations or communities sharing a particular characteristic, that have been systematically denied a full opportunity to participate in aspects of economic, social, and civic life.
- Underserved communities may include individuals who share one or more of the following characteristics:
 - ✓ Receive fewer transportation services compared to the general population.
 - ✓ Encounter barriers to accessing transportation services (e.g., economic, cultural, physical, and/or linguistic).
 - ✓ Have a lack of familiarity with the transportation system.
 - ✓ Face a shortage of readily available transportation providers.
 - Community team members must reside within a specific geographic region (city, town, county, tribal territory, or state) consistent with the geographical area where the transportation accessibility solution will be implemented. Applications from all types of regions are welcome and will be given full consideration, but we particularly encourage applications from rural areas and tribal territories.
 - The underserved community may include the entire geographic region, or a specific area of the region (e.g., a neighborhood).
- B) **Membership:** Community teams must be comprised of a minimum of five and maximum of twelve Participants (as defined above under *Key Terms*). Each CoP must also include a representative from a transportation organization. Additional representatives from Partner Organizations (as defined under *Key Terms*) are strongly encouraged to be part of the CoP.
- C) **Lead/co-leads:** For the purpose of the application, Community Teams must have an identified lead or co-leads who will serve as the point of contact.
- D) **Previous partnership:** Applicants consisting of some or all Participants and Community Partners who have worked together previously, will receive priority.
- E) **Previous identification of issues:** Applicants that have already identified transportation accessibility issues that they wish to address through the CoP and have an identified transportation accessibility solution for the problem will receive priority.

ATRC Support for CoPs

- ATRC staff roles:
 - An ATRC staff member will be assigned and will serve as a liaison for each Community Team.
 - The CoP structure and operations will be driven by the Community Team Participants. ATRC staff will provide guidance and advice to each Community Team on their development of a structure that results in achieving their goals and active and meaningful participation by all members in the CoP to address priority issues.
 - ATRC staff will not lead meetings, but instead support the community team to promote learning, problem solving, goal achievement and abide by the agreed upon structure.
 - ATRC staff will work together with the 5 community teams collectively, to identify emerging technical assistance themes across the 5 communities and develop CoP sessions to address identified technical assistance needs.

- ATRC will work with each community team to document their activities.
- ATRC staff will work along with the ACL Team to help communities connect with federal, state, and partners to achieve the communities' goal(s).
- Online community: An online message board and space to share resources and information (available in multiple languages as needed) among and across all 5 Community Teams will be available.

Informational Webinar for Prospective Applicants

An informational webinar will be held for prospective applicants on June 28, 2024 at 2:00 PM eastern. The ATRC team will provide an overview of the CoP, the application process, and will be available for any questions prospective applicants may have. [Register for the informational webinar at this link.](#)

Questions

Have questions? Need more information? Need assistance with your application? Please contact ATRC team members DeBrittany (Mitchell) Humphrey (debrittany.mitchell@umb.edu) or David Hoff (david.hoff@umb.edu).

ATRC CoP Timeline

June 2024:

- Application for CoP released.
- Information session held for potential applicants.

July 22, 2024:

- Deadline for submission of applications

August 9, 2024:

- Review of applications completed, communities selected and notified.

September 2024:

- First CoP meetings held.

October 2024:

- Charters for each CoP completed including workplan with timelines.

August 2025:

- Teams deliver final presentations sharing progress, solutions implemented, lessons learned, and plans for sustaining community teams that will inclusively focus on continuing to identify solutions, funding and outcomes for transportation accessibility issues in their community.

Application for ATRC Community of Practice Community Teams

Completed applications must be submitted by July 22, 2024, with the following information:

1. Lead applicant and organizational affiliation.
2. List of Participants as defined under *Key Terms* (minimum 5, maximum 12), who will serve on the community team, and for each Participant, their demographics (older adult, person with a disability). Also include a brief description of why each Participant will be involved including personal experience as a transportation user in dealing with accessibility issues. (maximum 350 characters per Participant)
3. List of Partner Organizations, as defined under *Key Terms*, who will participate on the community team. All community teams must include a transportation organization and may include up to 4 additional

Partner Organizations. (Note: Partner Organizations are separate from Participants, as defined under *Key Terms*.) For each Partner Organization, include type of organization, and the representative from each organization who will serve on the community team. Also include rationale for the partner's inclusion (maximum of 700 characters per Partner).

4. Description of your underserved community, including how your community meets the ATRC definition under *Key Terms*. (maximum 1,400 characters)
5. Type of community: urban, suburban, rural, tribal.
6. Provide a brief geographical description of the characteristics of the community? (maximum 500 characters)
7. What is the specific transportation accessibility problem on which your Community Team will focus? Provide a brief description of how the problem was identified and why your community wants to address this problem to meet the needs of your underserved community. (maximum 2,100 characters)
8. Have some or all of the members of the Community Team worked together previously? If so, please describe. (maximum 700 characters)
9. What partnerships or activities are currently in place that you can leverage to address the identified transportation accessibility problem and achieve your goals? (maximum 1,400 characters)
10. Has any previous work occurred to address the identified transportation accessibility problem? If yes, provide a brief summary of the work that has occurred, what has been accomplished, what the challenges are, who has been involved, and whether this work is completed or continuing. (maximum 2,100 characters)
11. Does the community team have a solution they are seeking to implement to address the identified problem? If yes, please describe. (maximum 1,400 characters)
12. What are your 12-month goals for the community team? What are the expected outcomes? (maximum 2,100 characters)
13. How will your community team engage with the larger community/region in your activities? (maximum 1,400 characters)

Additional information required:

- Letters of commitment are required from each Participant.
- For each application, a total of two original (non-form) letters of support are required from organizations that Community Team members have previously worked with.
- Letters of commitment from Partner Organizations that will work to address the identified transportation accessibility problem are helpful to include but not required.
- Budget for use of funds using provided online form and a brief budget justification (explanation of what each line item will be used for).

Budget Form		
Item	Amount	Description
Stipends for participation		
Disability accommodations		
Materials translation		
Language interpreters		
Other (specify)		
Other (specify)		

Other (specify):		
Total (maximum \$15,000)		

Instructions for Application Submission

1. [Applications may be submitted online at this link.](#)
2. If submitting the application online is not feasible, please contact DeBrittany (Mitchell) Humphrey – debrittany.mitchell@umb.edu or David Hoff – david.hoff@umb.edu, to discuss other options for submission of the application.
3. Please note the character limits for the narrative sections. The online application will not allow you to go beyond the character limits.
4. Before your online submission of the application, we strongly recommend preparing a document with all your question responses, that can be cut and pasted into the online application.
5. You will receive an email confirming that your application has been received. If you do not receive a confirmation email, your application has **not** been successfully submitted.
6. All applicants will be notified by August 9, 2024 regarding the status of their application.
7. Attachments are limited to letters of support. Do not include any additional items.
8. To request this information in an alternate format, contact Grayson Lee (lee@ctaa.org).